

The Science of Self Discipline

Each day begins with the same routine: meal prep completed, bag packed with gym clothes, entry made in the logbook. Each morning, before heading to class, I weigh myself and stick strictly to the routine I designed and committed to one year ago in the gym – nervous but set on making progress. Since then, every exercise routine, every meal consumed, every step taken has been recorded. What began as an endeavor to increase strength has blossomed into living with precision—precision that has come to include the friends with whom I share these experiences and mentor in theirs. Watching them connect meals to fitness uncovered something more within me—passion. Becoming a registered dietitian is what I aim to do, and Oakland University will be the starting line.

My experience here hasn't been straightforward. I was born in the U.S. and had ten years of grade school in Pontiac, Michigan before moving to Mexico with my family. In Mexico, I went to CEyTEM, a technical high school that opened me to more practical and intense learning. This experience in Mexico formed me; it gave me an appreciation for the structure that education can offer. When moving back to Pontiac, I was balancing education and maintaining a job working with my dad in construction—days in class and nights hanging drywall, completing rooms, learning to get my hands dirty. It was rough. But it made me realize how to hustle and stay focused regardless of what was happening surrounding me.

In Michigan, I was set on not letting anything get in the way. At Pontiac High School and Oakland Schools Technical Campus (OSTC), I got certification in areas such as software development, cybersecurity, and artificial intelligence – all in areas that didn't necessarily interest me in terms of pursuing those careers but areas that allowed me to continually develop and expand outside of one area. Not to mention that with such extensive coursework, I still managed to maintain a 4.0751 GPA and rank first in class, with hopes to be salutatorian (although these are but numeric accomplishments—success has been within).

The topics that revolve around nutrition, fitness, and biology got the best of me in the same way that my area of study did – through research and development with the sole intention of making not only myself better but those that need it as well. When I competed in powerlifting in Mexico, the more that I was intrigued about the way that the body reacted to nutrition and the biomechanics involved with movement to the point that even the slightest change within eating habits and training regimens made such a drastic difference. I was able to come up with a diet that I still stick to to this day, teach myself to cook to optimize nutritional values, and share what I was doing with others. When I got home from landscaping in the summer, there would be no greater luxury than to spend hours reading about types of muscular fiber and the implications that micronutrient deficiencies had in recovery.

What appeals to me about Oakland University is the depth and quality of its program in Nutrition and Dietetics—the emphasis on the medical as well as the more holistic aspects of health that affect whole communities rather than just isolated patients. What I hope to take away from this degree is more than just how to evaluate nutritional requirements for an individual; rather, I want to take away the knowledge and techniques to teach people to make viable lifestyle choices. The potential is clear that one individual with the right insight about the impact of food on one's own life has to offer to others; Oakland University is the place that will allow me to gain that credibility.

In the long run, I look forward to practicing as a registered dietitian with a focus on athletes and underserved communities; these groups are normally overlooked and misled with regard to matters of health and wellness. In my mind's eye, I envision starting up a private practice or perhaps working with some schools to teach young people about nutritional values early on in life before harmful notions take hold. I look forward to giving others the opportunity to change the way they look at food. What I've learned on my own path—across countries, construction projects, classrooms, and sports complexes—has shown me the importance of having structure, staying disciplined, and learning to believe in myself. The truth is that success has been shown to be more about blood, sweat, and tears in those quiet morning hours and endless nights; it has to do with taking data with you every step of the way and pushing forward during painful moments. When I look to Oakland University, though, I know that there exists an environment that values

such growth. Just like in the gym, just like on the job site – I'm ready to come to work every day and get the job done. Not just for me, but for people that I want to be able to help in the future. Oakland is where that future is going to start.